THE SCOREBOARD LIES

When Does a Successful Roam Become a Losing Play?

A Scenario-Based Analysis of Top-Lane Roaming Under High-Elo Solo Queue Conditions

Research question

To what extent can a kill-positive roam create negative net value once missed gold, experience, turret damage, wave state, recall timing and later objective control are considered?

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Independent portfolio study | July 2026

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A separate supporting workbook contains the same case data, formulas and charts used in the results section.

1. Game Context: How League of Legends Creates Advantage

League of Legends is a competitive strategy game in which each team attempts to reach and destroy the opposing Nexus. Combat is the most visible part of the game, but most matches are shaped by the way players use resources. Gold buys stronger items, experience unlocks levels and abilities, and map control creates access to turrets and neutral objectives. The result is simple, a play cannot be judged only by the fight that appears on screen.

To understand why a good-looking result may still be a bad trade, it is necessary to look at the resources that are gained, the resources that are given up and the time spent creating the play.

1.1 Laning, Resources and Conversion

The early part of a match is usually organised around lanes. A top laner gains most of their early gold and experience from minion waves, while also trying to deny the opponent access to the same resources. Turret damage, plates, recall timings and level advantages are ways of converting a good lane state into something more permanent.

Minion waves matter because they arrive repeatedly and create predictable windows. If a player leaves top lane, the opponent may collect the wave uncontested, damage the turret or change the wave into a freeze. The exact numbers can change between patches, especially after the large 2026 system updates, so this report focuses on relative differences instead of treating one reward value as permanent.

1.2 Tempo and Opportunity Cost

Tempo describes a player's ability to act before the opponent can answer without giving up too much somewhere else. A tempo advantage may allow a player to recall, establish vision, move toward another lane or contest an objective while the opponent is still occupied.

A roam is therefore not free movement across the map. It is an investment of time. The top laner temporarily gives up access to lane resources in exchange for a chance to create value elsewhere. Every roam has an opportunity cost, even when that cost is not immediately visible.

2. The Problem with Visible Success

2.1 What Is a Roam?

A roam occurs when a player temporarily leaves their assigned lane to create pressure or gain an advantage elsewhere on the map. The player gives up immediate access to lane resources in exchange for a possible benefit somewhere else.

Consider a common top-lane situation. After securing a takedown on the opposing laner, the player pushes the wave into the enemy turret. They remain healthy, their important abilities are available and they do not have enough gold for a meaningful purchase. At first glance, this looks like an ideal roaming window. The jungler is invading or the mid laner can create a numbers advantage, so the top laner moves toward the play.

By the time the player walks across the map, sets up the play and finishes it, the enemy top laner may have already respawned and returned. The roaming player now has another decision: recall and risk giving up control of the next wave, or return directly to lane without spending their gold. Neither option is always correct. The important question is whether the value created by the roam is greater than the value surrendered in top lane.

2.2 Immediate Reward and Hidden Cost

A kill or assist is instantly visible. It gives gold, experience and a clear positive signal. The team may also gain pressure or control over an objective. These rewards are real and may be enough to justify the move.

The cost is harder to notice. During the same time, the enemy top laner may collect one or more waves, gain a level, damage the turret or set up a freeze. Top lane makes this punishment especially important because the lane is long and often isolated. A small timing mistake can continue affecting the matchup after the player finally returns.

League of Legends is a team game, but each role still has local responsibilities. Helping the team can be correct, yet the player should still understand what they paid for that help. A successful-looking roam can improve the team position, damage the top-lane position, or do both at the same time.

2.3 The False-Positive Roam

For this study, a false-positive roam is a top-lane roam that produces an immediate and visible reward, such as a kill or assist, but creates a negative net strategic outcome once the resources, tempo and lane control surrendered are considered.

The term does not mean that every roam is wrong. Some roams are valid sacrifices for the team. A false positive is more specific, the play looks successful because of its immediate feedback, while the delayed result shows that the overall position became worse.

2.4 Measuring the True Value of a Roam

Rather than judging a roam only by its immediate result, let's measure how the game state changes from the moment the top laner leaves lane until 30, 60 and 90 seconds after the play.

$\mathbf{T_0}$	The moment the top laner leaves the lane.
$\mathbf{T_1}$	The moment the cross-map play ends.
$\mathbf{T_{30}}$	Thirty seconds after the play.
$\mathbf{T_{60}}$	Sixty seconds after the play.
$\mathbf{T_{90}}$	Ninety seconds after the play.

2.4.1 Immediate Visible Gold

$$\text{IVG} = \text{Kill Gold} + \text{Assist Gold} + \text{Direct Objective Gold}$$

IVG measures the immediate gold directly created by the roam. Non-economic results, such as a forced Flash, vision control or pressure, are recorded as strategic outcomes instead of being given an invented gold value.

2.4.2 Differential Change

$$\text{TeamSwing}_t = (\text{Ally Gold}_t\text{-Enemy Gold}_t)\text{-}(\text{Ally Gold}_0\text{-Enemy Gold}_0)$$

$$\text{TopSwing}_t = (\text{Player Gold}_t\text{-Enemy Top Gold}_t)\ \text{-}(\text{Player Gold}_0\text{-Enemy Top Gold}_0)$$

A positive result means the relative advantage improved. A negative result means it became worse. TeamSwing is treated as supporting evidence because unrelated events on the other side of the map may also change the total team gold difference.

2.4.3 Strategic Indicators

Gold does not describe the entire play, so every case also considers:

- CS and level difference
- Wave position and freeze risk
- Turret damage or plates lost
- Recall and Teleport timing
- Lane priority and return time
- Objective control and forced summoner spells

2.4.4 Outcome Classification

Clear positive	Both the team and top-lane positions improve.
Team-positive, personally costly	The team gains value while the top laner loses relative lane advantage.
Personal gain, poor team conversion	The top laner benefits, but the wider team outcome becomes negative.
Neutral or inconclusive	The changes are small or too affected by factors outside the roam.
False positive / clear negative	The visible result looks good but the delayed outcome is negative, or the play fails and creates further losses.

2.5 Illustrative Example

At T_0, the top laner holds a 400g advantage and the allied team is 300g ahead. After crashing the wave, the player roams toward mid lane. The allied mid laner receives 300g from the kill and the top laner gains 150g from an assist.

$$\text{IVG} = 300\text{g} + 150\text{g} = 450\text{g}$$

At T_1, the play looks successful. During the following 90 seconds, however, the enemy top laner collects two waves, damages the turret and gains a level. By T_{90}, the roaming player is 100g behind and the team lead has fallen to 100g.

$$\text{TeamSwing}_{90} = 100\text{g} - 300\text{g} = -200\text{g}$$

$$\text{TopSwing}_{90} = -100\text{g} - 400\text{g} = -500\text{g}$$

The play created 450g of immediate visible value, but the team lost 200g of its previous relative lead and the top laner suffered a 500g negative swing. The result would be classified as a false-positive roam with a clear negative delayed outcome.

3. Methodology

This is a scenario-based study. It applies the same evaluation to ten controlled hypothetical top-lane situations. The cases are built around realistic decisions, wave states and trade-offs, but they are not observations from recorded matches.

3.1 Scenario Design

Each scenario includes an intentional decision by the top laner to leave lane and create pressure elsewhere. The move may involve river support, a jungle invade, a mid-lane roam or a Teleport play. To keep the comparison focused, every case begins during the lane-focused part of the match and includes an observable starting wave state.

The ten scenarios were varied on purpose. Some begin from winning lanes, some from losing lanes, and some include no takedown at all. This makes it possible to compare identical immediate rewards under different conditions instead of building ten versions of the same result.

3.2 Data Points

Every case is described at T_0, T_1, T_{30}, T_{60} and T_{90}. The recorded values include the starting team and top-lane gold differences, the immediate reward, the later economic swing and the main strategic consequences. CS, level changes, turret pressure, recall timing, Teleport use and wave control are used as supporting context.

3.3 Evaluation Criteria

IVG measures the direct reward shown by the play. TeamSwing and TopSwing measure the delayed economic change. The final classification combines these numbers with the strategic state of top lane.

The classification is not based on the final result of the match. A team can win even if one roam was poor, and a correct roam can happen inside a lost game. The unit of analysis is the roam and the 90-second sequence that follows it.

3.4 Limitations

Champion matchups also change the cost of leaving lane. Some champions clear waves faster, damage turrets more effectively or return to lane more quickly. TeamSwing may also be influenced by events that are not caused by the roam. For these reasons, the framework is best treated as a structured review tool rather than a perfect prediction model.

4. Simulated Case Analysis

4.1 Case One - Clear Positive Roam

The top laner begins with a 150g advantage and the allied team is 50g ahead. After crashing two stacked waves into the enemy turret, the player moves into river to support the jungler. The wave preparation matters here because the opponent must spend time clearing before they can answer the move.

T_0	T_1	T_{60}	T_{90}
Top +150g; team +50g; two-wave crash; Teleport available.	Allied jungler gets the kill and the top laner receives assist gold.	The player recalls and returns without using Teleport. No plate is lost.	Top +250g; team +600g; level remains equal.
IVG	**$TeamSwing_{90}$**	**$TopSwing_{90}$**	**Final classification**
450g	+550g	+100g	**Clear positive roam**

Interpretation: The roam creates team value without giving away the original lane advantage. The important part is not only the kill, but the two-wave crash that made the move safe.

4.2 Case Two - Team-Positive, Personally Costly

The top laner starts 350g ahead, while the allied team is 150g behind. A standard wave is pushed into the turret and the player moves toward mid lane. The allied mid laner gets a kill and the top laner gains assist gold, but the return timing is slower than expected.

T_0	T_1	T_{60}	T_{90}
Top +350g; team -150g; standard crash.	Mid gets the kill; top receives assist gold.	Enemy top collects two waves and damages the turret while the roamer recalls.	Top gold is equal; team +450g.
IVG	**$TeamSwing_{90}$**	**$TopSwing_{90}$**	**Final classification**
450g	+600g	-350g	**Team-positive, personally costly**

Interpretation: The team gains a lot, but the top laner gives up the lead they had already built. This is not automatically a bad trade, but the personal cost should be recognized.

4.3 Case Three - False-Positive Roam

The top laner holds a 450g lead and the allied team is 100g ahead. After only a small crash, the player enters the enemy jungle to help an invade. The first part of the play succeeds, but the retreat lasts too long and the top laner remains away from lane.

T_0	T_1	T_{60}	T_{90}
Top +450g; team +100g; small crash.	One allied kill and assist gold for top.	The allied jungler is caught during the retreat, keeping the top laner away.	Top -150g; team -200g; enemy gains a level and wave control.
IVG	**$TeamSwing_{90}$**	**$TopSwing_{90}$**	**Final classification**
450g	-300g	-600g	**False-positive roam**

Interpretation: The scoreboard shows a successful play, but both the team and lane state are worse after 90 seconds. The visible reward hides a larger delayed loss.

4.4 Case Four - Neutral or Inconclusive

The top laner is 100g behind and the allied team is 50g ahead. After a full crash, the player moves into river because a jungle fight may start. No takedown happens, but the enemy jungler is forced to use Flash and leave the area.

T_0	T_1	T_{60}	T_{90}
Top -100g; team +50g; full crash.	No takedown; enemy jungler uses Flash.	The roamer returns after missing part of one wave; no plate is lost.	Top -150g; team +100g; lane remains broadly stable.
IVG	**$TeamSwing_{90}$**	**$TopSwing_{90}$**	**Final classification**
0g	+50g	-50g	**Neutral or inconclusive**

Interpretation: The forced Flash may become useful later, but the 90-second window cannot measure that future value. The small economic changes are not enough for a strong verdict.

4.5 Case Five - Personal Gain, Poor Team Conversion

The top lane matchup is even, while the allied team is 300g ahead. The top laner fast-pushes and joins a river fight. They secure one kill, but the allied mid laner and jungler both die as the fight continues.

T_0	T_1	T_{60}	T_{90}
Top equal; team +300g; fast push.	Top gains a kill and an ally gains assist gold.	Enemy controls river; opposing top collects one wave.	Top +250g; team -150g.
IVG	**$TeamSwing_{90}$**	**$TopSwing_{90}$**	**Final classification**
450g	-450g	+250g	**Personal gain, poor team conversion**

Interpretation: The player improves their own position, but the wider exchange is unfavorable. Personal success and team success are not always the same thing.

4.6 Case Six - Clear Negative Roam

The top laner begins 200g ahead and both teams are approximately equal. The player leaves a wave that is slowly pushing away from them and tries to create a mid-lane play. The attempt fails and the top laner dies without gaining a kill or assist.

T_0	T_1	T_{60}	T_{90}
Top +200g; teams equal; wave slowly pushes away.	The roaming top laner dies; no visible reward.	Enemy top freezes; Teleport is used defensively after respawn.	Top -300g; team -600g; wave control is lost.
IVG	**$TeamSwing_{90}$**	**$TopSwing_{90}$**	**Final classification**
0g	-600g	-500g	**Clear negative roam**

Interpretation: The play fails immediately and the wave state makes the loss worse. The player also spends Teleport just to limit further damage.

4.7 Case Seven - Sacrificial Teleport Play

The top laner is 150g behind and the allied team is 400g behind. After pushing the wave, the player uses Teleport to join a bottom-lane fight. The move creates two allied kills and gives the top laner assist gold on both takedowns.

T_0	T_1	T_{60}	T_{90}
Top -150g; team -400g; wave pushed; Teleport available.	Two allied kills and two assists for top.	Enemy top collects two waves and damages the turret.	Top -500g; team +450g.
IVG	**TeamSwing_{90}**	**TopSwing_{90}**	**Final classification**
900g	+850g	-350g	**Team-positive, personally costly**

Interpretation: The player pays a clear personal cost, but the play reverses the wider team position. This is a good example of a sacrifice that can still be correct.

4.8 Case Eight - Successful Comeback Roam

The top laner is 250g behind and the allied team is 100g behind. The enemy top laner recalls, so the player pushes the wave and moves into river. The roaming player kills the enemy jungler and uses the resulting timing to take a clean recall.

T_0	T_1	T_{60}	T_{90}
Top -250g; team -100g; enemy top has recalled.	Top secures the kill; allied jungler gets assist gold.	The player recalls, buys an item component and returns on time.	Top +50g; team +350g.
IVG	**TeamSwing_{90}**	**TopSwing_{90}**	**Final classification**
450g	+450g	+300g	**Clear positive roam**

Interpretation: The roam turns a losing position into a small lead for both the player and the team. The opponent recall creates the window and limits the lane cost.

4.9 Case Nine - Teleport False Positive

The top laner is 300g ahead and the allied team leads by 250g. They use Teleport to join a bottom-lane fight while a large enemy wave is approaching the top turret. The allied marksman gets a kill and the top laner receives assist gold.

T_0	T_1	T_{60}	T_{90}
Top +300g; team +250g; large enemy wave approaching top.	One allied kill and assist gold for top.	Enemy top collects multiple waves and deals heavy turret damage.	Top -550g; team -100g; Teleport is unavailable for the return.
IVG	**$TeamSwing_{90}$**	**$TopSwing_{90}$**	**Final classification**
450g	-350g	-850g	**False-positive roam**

Interpretation: The kill looks good, but it does not cover the resources lost in top lane. The wave state and the use of Teleport make the punishment much larger.

4.10 Case Ten - Positive Value Without Immediate Gold

The top laner is 50g behind and the teams are equal. After pushing the wave, the player moves into river to protect the allied jungler during an objective setup. No kill or assist occurs, but the enemy jungler is forced to leave and the allied team gains control of the area.

T_0	T_1	T_{60}	T_{90}
Top -50g; teams equal; wave pushed.	No takedown; enemy jungler retreats.	The allied team secures the objective and top returns without losing a plate.	Top equal; team +250g.
IVG	**$TeamSwing_{90}$**	**$TopSwing_{90}$**	**Final classification**
0g	+250g	+50g	**Clear positive, zero IVG**

Interpretation: The scoreboard shows no takedown, but the move still creates useful pressure and objective control. A roam can be valuable even when IVG is zero.

4.11 Results Summary

10	2	6
controlled scenarios	false-positive outcomes	cases with the same 450g IVG

Case	IVG	$TeamSwing_{90}$	$TopSwing_{90}$	Classification
1	450g	+550g	+100g	Clear positive
2	450g	+600g	-350g	Team-positive, personally costly
3	450g	-300g	-600g	False positive
4	0g	+50g	-50g	Neutral or inconclusive
5	450g	-450g	+250g	Personal gain, poor team conversion
6	0g	-600g	-500g	Clear negative
7	900g	+850g	-350g	Team-positive, personally costly
8	450g	+450g	+300g	Clear positive
9	450g	-350g	-850g	False positive
10	0g	+250g	+50g	Clear positive, zero IVG

The most useful comparison is not the average result, because these cases were intentionally designed to cover different outcomes. The clearer finding is that the same IVG can lead to opposite delayed results. An IVG of 450g appears in six cases, yet the classifications range from clear positive to false positive. Case Ten also creates positive value with no immediate visible gold at all.

5. Conclusion

This scenario-based study examined whether a top-lane roam should be judged only by its immediate visible result. The ten cases show why that approach is unreliable. The same 450g reward can lead to a clear win, a personal sacrifice, a poor team trade or a false-positive result, depending on the starting wave, the duration of the play and the opponent's ability to convert the absence.

IVG is useful because it records the reward that players notice first. It is not enough on its own. TeamSwing and TopSwing show how the economic position changes, while wave state, level timing, turret pressure and Teleport explain why that change happened.

The main conclusion is not that roaming is bad. Roaming can be one of the strongest ways for a top laner to affect the map. The point is that success should be measured against the cost. A kill-positive play deserves celebration only after the player understands what was gained and what was left behind.